



Maritime &
Coastguard
Agency

Guidance

MIN 723 (M+F) Ballast water management: the intra north sea ballast water contingency area

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Summary

This Marine Information Note is to highlight the establishment of the Intra North Sea Contingency Area for the purpose of ballast water exchange and treatment in accordance with BWM.2/Circ.62 and Resolution MEPC.387(81).

1. Introduction/background

1.1 The meeting of the OSPAR Commission on 19 June 2025 recognised and welcomed the establishment of a new Intra North Sea Ballast Water Contingency Area (“Contingency Area”).

1.2 The purpose of the Contingency Area is to facilitate the handling of non-compliant ballast water in conjunction with BWM.2/Circ.62 and Resolution MEPC.387(81).

1.3 The UK are recognising the Contingency Area and raising awareness of its availability as a contingency measure for eligible ships.

2. Expired Intra North Sea Ballast Water Exchange Area

2.1 Regulation B-4.2 of the Ballast Water Management Convention (“the Convention”) allows Port States in certain circumstances and in consultation with other States to designate areas where ships may conduct ballast water exchange.

2.2 The Intra North Sea Ballast Water Exchange Area was a designated area under Regulation B-4.2 where a ship which was required under the Convention to meet the standard described in regulation D-1 and was on a voyage between 2 North Sea ports could conduct ballast water exchange.

2.3 The Intra North Sea Ballast Water Exchange Area has now expired. It came into effect when the Convention entered into force on 8 September 2017 and expired when ships were required to meet regulation D-2 of the Convention, as outlined in IMO resolution A.1088(28).

3. Establishment of the Intra North Sea Ballast Water Contingency Area

3.1 Since the expiration of the Intra North Sea Ballast Water Exchange Area, challenging water quality has continued to affect operations in ports in North Sea States.

3.2 As a result, Belgium, Denmark, Germany, Norway, the Netherlands, Sweden and the United Kingdom have collaborated to establish the Contingency Area for the purpose of Ballast Water Exchange plus Treatment (BWMS) in accordance with BWM.2/Circ.62 and Resolution MEPC.387(81).

3.3 A ship may only use the Contingency Area, as delimited by co-ordinates in Annex 2 of the OSPAR Summary Record (https://www.ospar.org/site/assets/files/63848/annex10_intra-north-sea-bw-contingency-area.pdf), for an exchange using the BWMS if it meets the requirements laid out in Section 4 of the same Summary Record.

3.4 This Contingency Area will expire on 26 June 2030 unless extended by the aforementioned States and will be reviewed on a yearly basis to update the map and coordinates as appropriate.

3.5 Further information, including a map of the Contingency Area has been published on the OSPAR website here: <https://www.ospar.org/work-areas/eiha/shipping/ballast-and-biofouling> (<https://www.ospar.org/work-areas/eiha/shipping/ballast-and-biofouling>).

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